around the world. A few noteworthy projects are making progress. One of them is the Simputer. It aims at providing access to computing at the grass root levels in India, and its ultimate goal is to enable illiterate people to use the device. Thus it aims at being inexpensive and Indianised. The Simputer trust has been developed to ensure that such a noble project does not fade away due to lack of interest or funding.

The problem with Linux lies in the availability of application software. Unlike Windows-based application software, Linux-based software isn't freely available, even in software stores. The major reason for this, in turn, is the lack of popularity of Linux. Then again, if it were popular and available in stores, the cost factor of buying Linux application software would come into play.

Trevor Warren, consultant for Red Hat, encompasses the problem of Distribution very simply, "Whatever your required application, there is a good chance you get it off the Net. Popular distributions provide a large number of applications off the box. The specific application that you may need is just a download away."

Linux is a lot more than a cheap buy.

Frederick Noronha

A freelance writer and an active member of the Linux community

> "Business takes a conservative approach. Trying to implement something that will take time and effort to understand defeats the principle of savings in free software."

On its own, it is a stable solution and a great choice for many computing needs. This could be a very important reason for people to switch to Linux. When you run applications on a Windows environment, invariably you encounter a system crash or a lock-up at some point or the other. A very important fact that most experienced Windows users overlook is the underlying anxiety while working on the system. This anxiety is due to the worry that a system crash or lock-up can potentially disrupt an entire days work. But this is not so in the case of Linux. Since it is a derivative of Unix, its stability cannot be questioned. Uptime is usually measured in terms of weeks and months for a Unix-based OS.

The common perception of users is that Linux does not have technical support. But this is not true. The reason behind this is that people do not search for support in the right places. Similar to its distribution model, support for Linux is also based primarily on the Internet. For technical support, the open source community is the best solution.

But According to Trevor Warren, "The system of support is the same for Windows or Red Hat. Support and updates are available off the Web." Adding to this, you can also expect support from the large online Linux community.

To save on costs, State Institutions are ideally suited to switch to Linux. The West Bengal Pollution Control (WBPC) board has undertaken a project to develop an information system for their entire network, titled the 'Environment Man-

IIT: Affordable solutions for everyone!

The IITs have always been at the forefront of research into new horizons. With the Affordable Solutions Lab (ASL) at the Kanwal Rekhi School of Information Technology (KReSIT), practical deployment of Linux is now possible. The ASL is walking the thin line of making computational facilities cheaper without having to compromise on performance.

ASL can be called a simulation environment in the simplest of terms. Corporations interested in switching to low cost systems can bring their needs to the lab. Based on these needs, a test bed is set up, and the corporations can see their system function exactly as it will, when implemented. Also, the hesitation to make the switch is removed with the presence of such an institution as an IIT offering support.

Though the lab is in its initial stages, a lot of progress has already been made. During the set up, a set of tests are performed which make assessments regarding the performance, stability and security of a system. The basic set up is a server with connected diskless nodes (also called 'thin clients'), which receive information via a browser environment. This reduces the thin client system requirements, and ultimately the cost of the entire network. A typical thin client costs only about Rs 15,000, as opposed to Rs 20,000 for normal entry level desktop PCs.

Dr. Deepak B. Phatak is a professor who is closely involved with the operations of the lab. He is extremely optimistic about the results. According to him, the acceptance of a cheaper solution will be possible only if the end user is convinced that the solution is a safe and workable one. According to him the lack of interest for an Open Source OS is due to lack of applications. The only way that users can try out the OS is if applications do exist. But this results in a vicious cycle as major software developers will only make applications if a market exists for them. He believes that projects such as the ASL can help break this cycle. By providing a solution and backing it with the ASL name, an end user will feel reassured about trying out the system.

When asked about computing in general in India, he feels that a mutual participation is required. According to him, for Computer penetration to increase at a faster pace, his plan must be adopted.

Dr. Phatak says, "Governments, schools, colleges must increase their investment in IT by a factor of 4. At the same time, the industry should give solutions at a quarter of the current cost. 20 Million desktop PCs must be sold in order to make India an IT powerhouse. A 16X growth factor is required to attain this. This is only possible when the cost of a desktop drops to Rs 15,000. Only then will people will believe it. The ultimate aim is to make a PC cost less than a TV".